



CSE200 - Technical Writing and Presentation

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Participatory Design Method

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Contents

1	Introduction	3
1.1	From User-Centred to Participatory Design	3
1.2	The Collaboration Model	4
2	Historical Background and Evolution	4
2.1	The Problem Before Participatory Design	4
2.2	Origins: The Scandinavian Workplace Democracy Movement	5
2.3	How Participatory Design Solved It	5
3	Core Principles of Participatory Design	6
4	The Participatory Design Process	7
4.1	Simple Model of Iteration	7
4.2	Overall Process Flowchart	8
5	Stage 0: Planning and Stakeholder Identification	9
5.1	Power–Interest Grid	9
5.2	Levels of Participation	9
6	Stage 1: Initial Exploration of Work	10
6.1	Techniques	10
6.2	How Many Sessions?	10
7	Stage 2: Discovery Processes	10
7.1	Discovery Techniques	10
7.2	Future Workshop Structure	11
7.3	Card Sorting Analysis	11
7.4	Affinity Diagramming	12
7.5	Collaborative Prioritization	12
8	Stage 3: Prototyping	13
8.1	Prototyping Techniques	13
8.2	Fidelity versus Cost	13
8.3	Iterative Prototyping Loop	14
9	Stage 4: Evaluation	15
9.1	Usability Evaluation	15
9.2	Evaluating the Participation Itself	15
10	Facilitating a Participatory Workshop	16
11	Summary of Techniques	16
12	Real-World Applications of Participatory Design	16

13 Benefits of Participatory Design	18
13.1 Voice and Ownership	18
13.2 Context and Domain Knowledge	18
13.3 Improved Usability and Feasibility	18
13.4 Diverse Perspectives and Innovation	19
13.5 The Flow of Benefits	19
14 Challenges of Participatory Design	19
14.1 Conflicting Needs	19
14.2 Time and Logistics	19
14.3 Trust and Expectations	19
14.4 Participation and Privacy	20
14.4.1 The Need-to-Know Boundary	20
14.5 Managing the Challenges	20
15 Conclusion	21
15.1 The Central Takeaway	21
References	23

List of Figures

1 The pre-PD, one-way design flow	5
2 Timeline of Participatory Design from its Scandinavian origins to today	5
3 From a one-way handoff to a cyclical, co-owned process	6
4 The iterative Participatory Design cycle	7
5 Flowchart of the complete Participatory Design process	8
6 Power–Interest grid used to plan participation	9
7 Ladder of participation; genuine PD targets the upper rungs	9
8 The phases of a Future Workshop	11
9 Dendrogram of the example card sort; cutting at τ gives two categories	12
10 Affinity diagram: raw observations clustered into themes	12
11 Iterative cooperative prototyping loop	14
12 The people–insight–outcome relationship in Participatory Design	19
13 People, insight and outcome in Participatory Design	21
14 The shift from designing for people to designing with people	21

List of Tables

1 User-Centred Design versus Participatory Design	4
2 The Participatory Design collaboration model	4
3 Core principles of Participatory Design	6
4 Example prioritization outcome of a discovery workshop	13
5 Summary of evaluation metrics in Participatory Design	15
6 Participatory Design techniques mapped to process stages	16
7 Approaches for balancing participation and privacy	20
8 Major challenges and corresponding responses	21

Participatory Design Method

Abstract

Participatory Design (PD) is a design approach in which the people who will use a system take part in designing it as equal partners, rather than serving only as sources of requirements or test subjects. PD grew out of the Scandinavian workplace democracy movement of the 1970s, which aimed to give workers a real voice in the technologies that shaped their jobs. Since then it has spread to software engineering, human–computer interaction, healthcare, education and public services. In this report we introduce the method and trace its history. We then describe its process, from planning and initial exploration of work through discovery, prototyping and evaluation, together with the key techniques used in each stage, such as contextual inquiry, future workshops, card sorting and cooperative prototyping. We also discuss applications of PD in different domains, its benefits, such as better usability, deeper insight into real work and a stronger sense of ownership, and its challenges, such as conflicting needs, limited time, trust and privacy. We show that, when users hold genuine decision-making power, PD produces systems that fit real work practices and that the people who use them truly own.

1 Introduction

Participatory Design (PD) is an approach to designing systems, tools and work environments in which the people who will use them, together with workers, managers and other affected stakeholders, take part as active **co-designers** rather than serving merely as people whom designers observe, interview or ask to test a finished product [1, 2]. This is what separates PD from conventional user-centred design (UCD): in UCD, designers study users and design *for* them, whereas in PD, designers and users design *with* each other, and designers share decision-making power with users instead of holding it alone. Three ideas underpin this shift. First, PD treats end users as **design partners**, not as test subjects whose only role is to react to something already built. Second, PD deliberately blends the **tacit knowledge** that users hold about their own work with the formal expertise of professional designers. Users often find this knowledge difficult to state explicitly but easy to demonstrate. Third, this blending of knowledge forms the conceptual foundation of many present-day **design patterns** and co-creation methods, from design-thinking workshops to agile story mapping.

1.1 From User-Centred to Participatory Design

Table 1 contrasts the two design postures. The essential difference is the direction in which information and authority flow: in UCD it flows one way, from user to designer; in PD it flows both ways, and this reversal shifts the balance of power toward the people who will actually use the system.

Aspect	User-Centred Design	Participatory Design
Role of the user	Information source / test subject	Co-designer with a voice in decisions
Direction of knowledge	One-way: designer studies user	Two-way: designer and user learn from each other
Decision authority	Held by the design team	Shared between designers and participants

Table 1: User-Centred Design versus Participatory Design

1.2 The Collaboration Model

Meaningful participation depends on bringing together two different kinds of knowledge. Designers contribute **professional design knowledge**: methods, tools and an understanding of what is technically feasible. Participants contribute **lived, real-world knowledge**: the practical and contextual understanding of how the work is actually done. Table 2 summarizes what each side contributes and what emerges where the two overlap.

Contributor	Contribution
Designers	Professional design knowledge: methods, tools, technical feasibility
Participants	Lived, real-world knowledge: work practice, context, everyday constraints
Overlap	Shared understanding, collaboration and capacity-building, supported by common materials (sketches, cards, prototypes) and a shared design environment

Table 2: The Participatory Design collaboration model

This overlap does not occur in isolation. The wider society and culture in which the project takes place surround and constrain it. They also shape which solutions are acceptable, adoptable and sustainable in practice.

2 Historical Background and Evolution

2.1 The Problem Before Participatory Design

Before PD became established practice, designers and managers created workplace systems and tools in a **top-down, designer-centric** manner, as Figure 1 illustrates. Decisions flowed in one direction only, from management and designers down to the people who would actually use the resulting system.

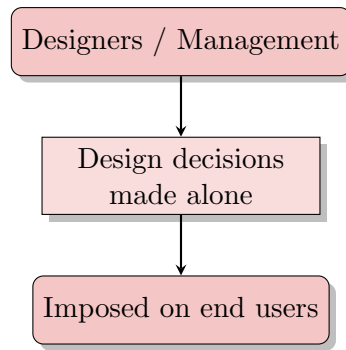


Figure 1: The pre-PD, one-way design flow

Under this model, designers largely ignored users’ real needs, context and hard-won workplace expertise. Users could give feedback only *after* launch, when fixing the system was slow, costly or simply impossible. The consequences were predictable: poor usability, low adoption, resistance from the workforce and systems that were technically complete yet solved the *wrong* problem.

2.2 Origins: The Scandinavian Workplace Democracy Movement

PD emerged directly as a response to this problem, rooted in the **Scandinavian workplace democracy movement** of the 1970s [3, 4]. Trade unions in Norway, Sweden and Denmark argued that if new computer technology was going to reshape how people worked, the workers affected by that change had a democratic right to help design it, rather than merely giving opinions afterward. Figure 2 traces the resulting evolution of PD from this labour-movement origin to its present form.



Figure 2: Timeline of Participatory Design from its Scandinavian origins to today

Key Milestone

The **UTOPIA project** (Scandinavia, late 1970s–80s) brought Nordic trade unions together with researchers to let *typesetters*, whose jobs were directly threatened by new computer typesetting systems, co-design their own tools. Many researchers regard it as the origin of Participatory Design [3].

2.3 How Participatory Design Solved It

Figure 3 contrasts the pre-PD flow with the participatory alternative it gave rise to.

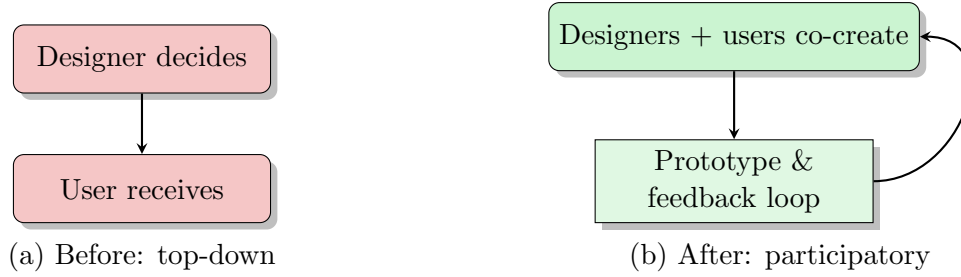


Figure 3: From a one-way handoff to a cyclical, co-owned process

Empowerment replaced imposition: stakeholders gained a genuine voice and real decision-making power, and design became an **iterative, cyclical conversation** between designers and users rather than a one-time handoff from one side to the other.

3 Core Principles of Participatory Design

The historical shift described above rests on four core principles that recur throughout every stage of the PD process described in the remainder of this report. Table 3 summarizes them.

Principle	Description
Mutual Learning	Designers learn the domain from users, while users learn design thinking from designers; knowledge flows in both directions and builds a shared understanding.
Co-creation & Ownership	Designers build the system together with its future users, so that it feels like theirs; shared ownership leads to stronger buy-in and better long-term outcomes.
Iterative Prototyping	Design proceeds through small, testable steps rather than one big launch; rapid build–test–refine cycles keep the design grounded in real practice.
Democratic Decision-Making	No single voice, whether manager, designer or senior user, controls the outcome; every stakeholder holds an equal seat at the table.

Table 3: Core principles of Participatory Design

These four principles are not independent add-ons; they reinforce one another. Democratic decision-making only functions once mutual learning has given every participant enough shared understanding to make an informed choice, and iterative prototyping is what turns co-creation from a one-off workshop into genuine, lasting ownership of the final system. The remainder of this report describes the concrete process and techniques through which PD teams put these principles into practice.

4 The Participatory Design Process

We describe PD as a structured yet iterative process in which designers, developers and end users act as **co-designers** [1, 2]. Following the widely used three-stage framework of Spinuzzi [5], we divide the process into the following stages:

1. **Initial Exploration of Work:** Designers meet the users, observe how people currently work and understand the tools, workflows, routines and social context.
2. **Discovery Processes:** Designers and users collaboratively clarify goals, values and the desired outcome of the system, using workshops, storytelling and organizing techniques.
3. **Prototyping:** Users and designers iteratively shape technological artifacts (paper mock-ups, low- and high-fidelity prototypes) until the design fits the envisioned work practice.

Before and after these three core stages, practical projects also include a **planning** stage (stakeholder identification, recruitment) and an **evaluation & deployment** stage. Figure 4 shows the complete cycle.

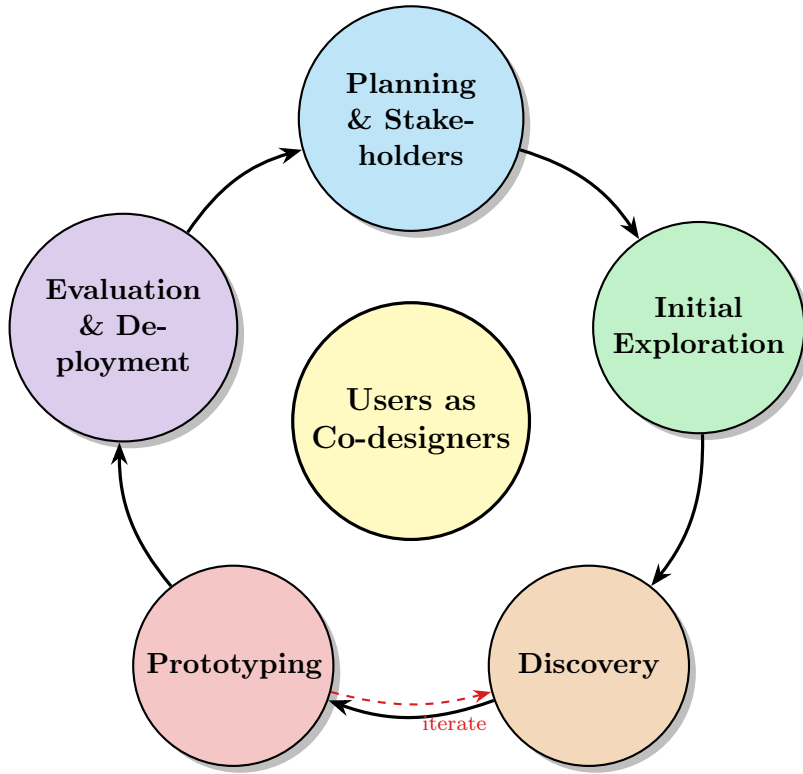


Figure 4: The iterative Participatory Design cycle

4.1 Simple Model of Iteration

Each iteration improves the design using the feedback of all participants. If D_k is the design after iteration k and f_u is the feedback of participant u among N participants, then

$$D_{k+1} = D_k + \frac{1}{N} \sum_{u=1}^N f_u(D_k) \quad (1)$$

Every participant gets an equal voice, $w_u = 1/N$, which reflects the democratic nature of PD.

4.2 Overall Process Flowchart

Figure 5 shows the complete process as a flowchart, including the loops back to prototyping and discovery.

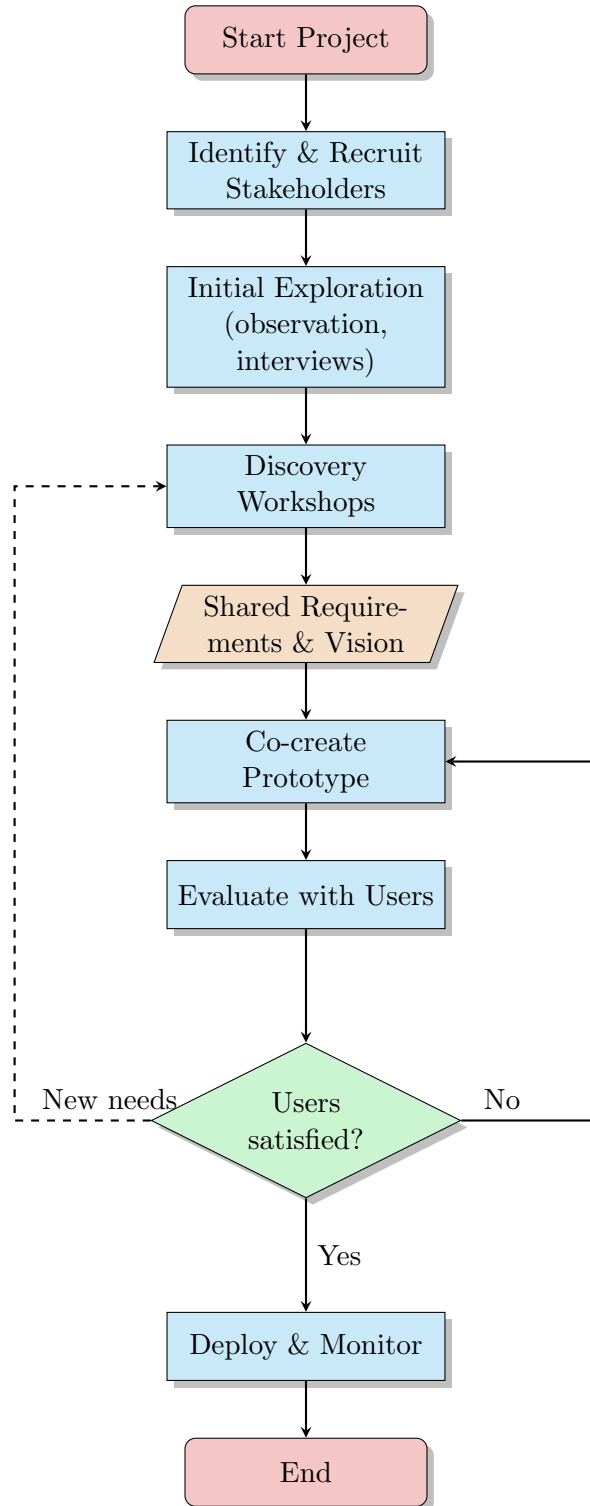


Figure 5: Flowchart of the complete Participatory Design process

5 Stage 0: Planning and Stakeholder Identification

Participation is only meaningful when the *right* people participate. The planning stage identifies every group that will use the system, feel its effects or influence it.

Designers usually map stakeholders by their **power** and **interest** [6]. PD gives special attention to end users who are strongly affected by the system but have little power, so that their voice is not lost. Figure 6 shows the power–interest grid that we use to plan participation.

5.1 Power–Interest Grid

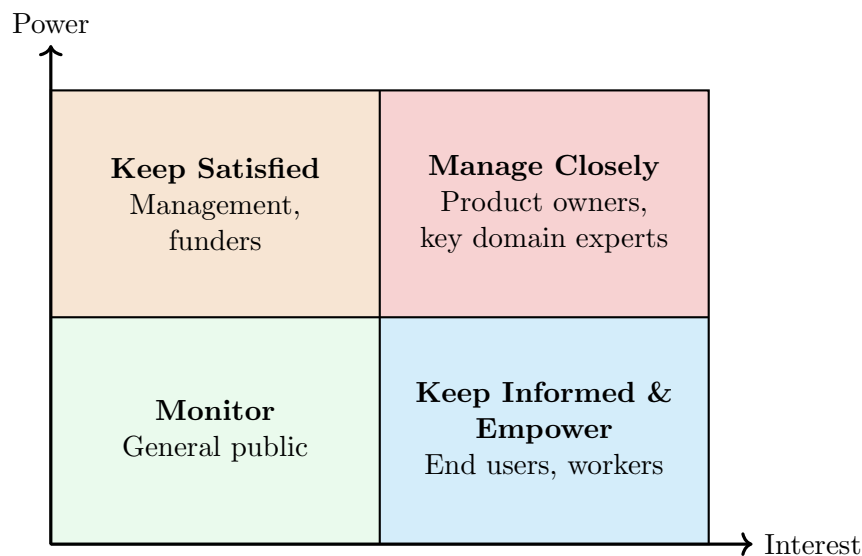


Figure 6: Power–Interest grid used to plan participation

5.2 Levels of Participation

Not every project gives users the same influence. The project team uses Arnstein’s *Ladder of Participation* [7] to decide the intended level before the project starts. Figure 7 shows the eight rungs of the ladder, grouped into non-participation, tokenism and real power.

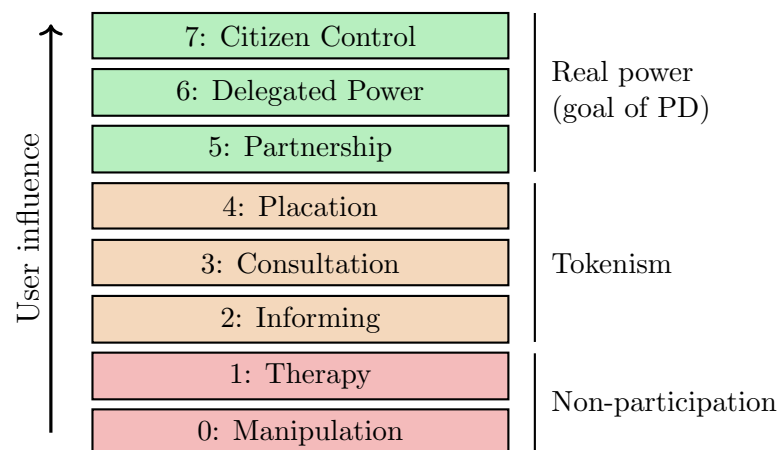


Figure 7: Ladder of participation; genuine PD targets the upper rungs

6 Stage 1: Initial Exploration of Work

In this stage designers enter the users’ world. The goal is to understand *tacit knowledge*: the skills and routines users apply without being able to easily describe them.

6.1 Techniques

- **Ethnographic Observation:** Designers observe users in their natural working environment over days or weeks.
- **Contextual Inquiry:** A master–apprentice style interview while the user performs real tasks; the designer asks “why” at every step [8].
- **Walkthroughs:** Users walk designers through a typical day or process, explaining each artifact they use.
- **Artifact Analysis:** Designers collect and study the forms, notes, spreadsheets and “workarounds” that users create.
- **Semi-structured Interviews:** Flexible interviews guided by open-ended questions.

6.2 How Many Sessions?

Exploration continues until new sessions stop revealing new themes. If T_n is the number of themes found after n sessions, the share of new themes is

$$\rho_n = \frac{T_n - T_{n-1}}{T_{n-1}} \quad (2)$$

and exploration can stop when ρ_n becomes very small (e.g. below 5%). In practice, small repeated sessions with around five users each already uncover most of the important problems [9, 10].

7 Stage 2: Discovery Processes

The discovery stage brings designers and users together to *interpret* what they observed and to envision the future. Its outputs are shared goals, prioritized requirements and a common language.

7.1 Discovery Techniques

- **Future Workshop:** A three-phase workshop (Critique → Fantasy → Implementation) that moves from problems to utopian ideas to realistic plans [11].
- **Card Sorting:** Participants group cards containing features or concepts into categories that make sense to them, revealing their mental model [12].
- **Affinity Diagramming:** Participants write observations on sticky notes and cluster them by similarity to reveal themes.

- **Storytelling and Scenarios:** Users narrate real incidents; these become scenarios and personas.
- **Organizational Games:** Role-play of workflows using cards and boards to explore alternatives.
- **Design Games (e.g. CARD, Layout Kit):** Game-like tools that let non-technical users express design ideas.
- **Mock-ups and Collages:** Users create visual collages expressing feelings and expectations.

7.2 Future Workshop Structure

Figure 8 shows the four phases of a Future Workshop.

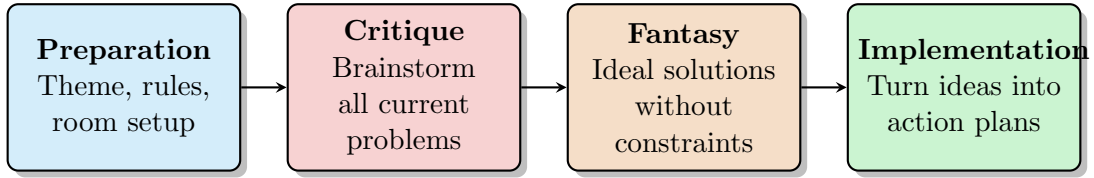


Figure 8: The phases of a Future Workshop

7.3 Card Sorting Analysis

Suppose N participants sort m cards. For each pair of cards (i, j) let n_{ij} be the number of participants who placed both cards in the same group. The **similarity matrix** is

$$S_{ij} = \frac{n_{ij}}{N}, \quad 0 \leq S_{ij} \leq 1, \quad S_{ii} = 1 \quad (3)$$

and the corresponding distance matrix is $d_{ij} = 1 - S_{ij}$. For example, with four cards and $N = 10$ participants:

$$S = \begin{bmatrix} 1.0 & 0.8 & 0.1 & 0.2 \\ 0.8 & 1.0 & 0.2 & 0.1 \\ 0.1 & 0.2 & 1.0 & 0.9 \\ 0.2 & 0.1 & 0.9 & 1.0 \end{bmatrix} \quad (4)$$

Cards 1–2 and 3–4 clearly form two groups. We merge cards with high similarity step by step, as Algorithm 1 describes, and Figure 9 shows the resulting dendrogram.

Algorithm 1 Hierarchical Clustering of Card Sort Data

Require: Card sorts from N participants, m cards, cut threshold τ

- 1: Compute n_{ij} for all pairs; set $S_{ij} \leftarrow n_{ij}/N$, $d_{ij} \leftarrow 1 - S_{ij}$
 - 2: Initialize clusters $C \leftarrow \{\{1\}, \{2\}, \dots, \{m\}\}$
 - 3: **while** $|C| > 1$ **do**
 - 4: Find $(A, B) = \arg \min_{A \neq B \in C} d(A, B)$
 - 5: **if** $d(A, B) > \tau$ **then**
 - 6: **break** ▷ remaining groups are too dissimilar
 - 7: **end if**
 - 8: $C \leftarrow (C \setminus \{A, B\}) \cup \{A \cup B\}$
 - 9: Record merge $(A, B, d(A, B))$ in dendrogram
 - 10: **end while**
 - 11: **return** C as the categories of the information architecture
-

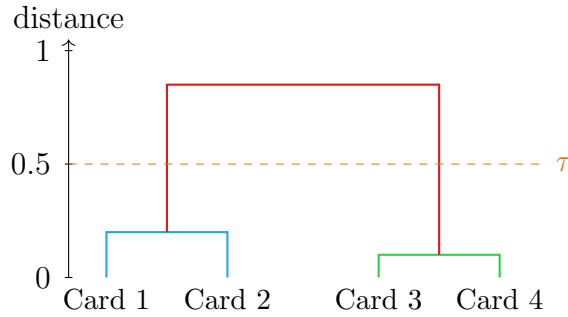


Figure 9: Dendrogram of the example card sort; cutting at τ gives two categories

7.4 Affinity Diagramming

Figure 10 shows an example affinity diagram, in which raw observations form three themes.

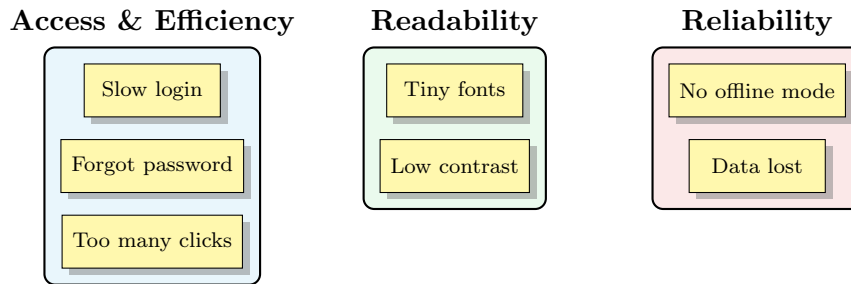


Figure 10: Affinity diagram: raw observations clustered into themes

7.5 Collaborative Prioritization

After collecting ideas, participants prioritize them together, most commonly by dot voting. Table 4 shows an example outcome.

Dot Voting. Each participant u receives k dots to distribute among m ideas. The score of idea j is

$$V_j = \sum_{u=1}^N v_{uj}, \quad \sum_{j=1}^m v_{uj} = k \quad (5)$$

where v_{uj} is the number of dots that participant u gives to idea j .

Idea	Dot votes V_j	Final Rank
Offline mode	14	1
Larger font option	11	2
One-click login	9	3
Dark theme	4	4

Table 4: Example prioritization outcome of a discovery workshop

8 Stage 3: Prototyping

In the prototyping stage, the shared vision becomes tangible. Users do not only comment on prototypes; they **build and modify** them.

8.1 Prototyping Techniques

- **Paper Prototyping:** Designers draw screens on paper; one person “plays computer” while users interact.
- **PICTIVE** (Plastic Interface for Collaborative Technology Initiatives through Video Exploration): Users and developers arrange paper and plastic interface elements on a shared table while a camera records the session [13].
- **Cooperative Prototyping:** Designers change a software prototype live while users test it [14].
- **Wizard of Oz:** A hidden human simulates system intelligence, allowing users to test concepts that are not yet built [15].
- **Mock-ups and Role-play:** Physical models of devices or work spaces used in realistic scenarios.
- **Low- to High-fidelity progression:** Sketches $\rightarrow$ wireframes $\rightarrow$ clickable prototypes $\rightarrow$ functional systems.

8.2 Fidelity versus Cost

Changing a high-fidelity prototype is far more expensive than changing a paper sketch. Therefore PD starts with cheap, low-fidelity materials and raises fidelity only as the design becomes stable.

8.3 Iterative Prototyping Loop

Figure 11 shows the iterative prototyping loop, and Algorithm 2 describes one cooperative prototyping session in detail. Both use the System Usability Scale (SUS) score, a usability rating from zero to 100 that Section 9 explains.

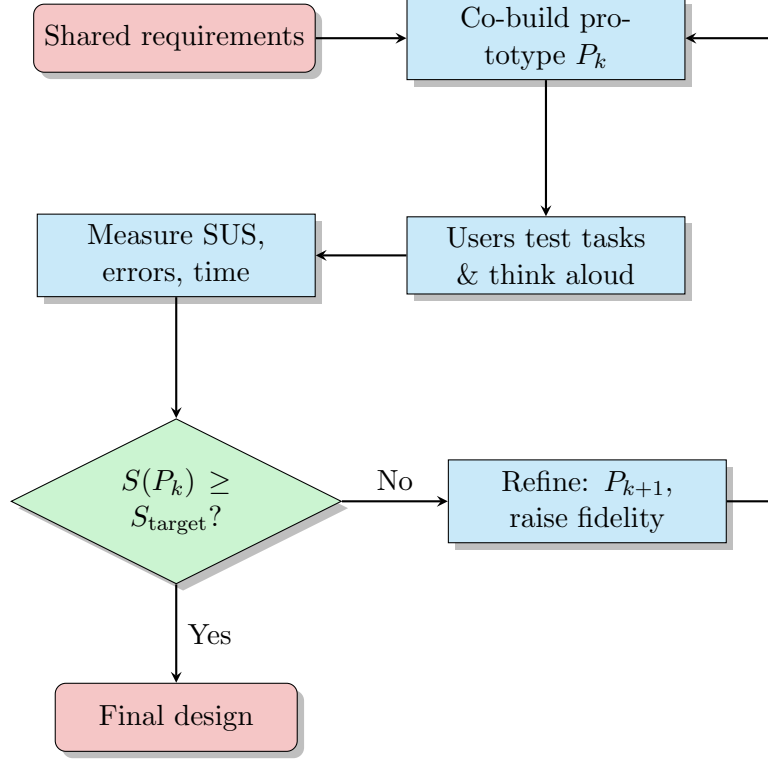


Figure 11: Iterative cooperative prototyping loop

Algorithm 2 Cooperative Prototyping Session

Require: Requirements R , participants U , target score S_{target} , max iterations K

- 1: $P_0 \leftarrow$ low-fidelity paper prototype from R ; $k \leftarrow 0$
 - 2: **repeat**
 - 3: **for all** $u \in U$ **do**
 - 4: u performs scenario tasks on P_k while thinking aloud
 - 5: Record issues I_u , task time t_u , success s_u , SUS score SUS_u
 - 6: u physically modifies P_k to show preferred solution
 - 7: **end for**
 - 8: $I \leftarrow \bigcup_u I_u$; rank issues by severity $\times$ frequency
 - 9: $S(P_k) \leftarrow \frac{1}{|U|} \sum_u \text{SUS}_u$
 - 10: Designers and users jointly agree on changes Δ_k
 - 11: $P_{k+1} \leftarrow P_k + \Delta_k$; increase fidelity if issues become minor
 - 12: $k \leftarrow k + 1$
 - 13: **until** $S(P_k) \geq S_{\text{target}}$ **or** $k = K$
 - 14: **return** P_k
-

9 Stage 4: Evaluation

9.1 Usability Evaluation

System Usability Scale (SUS) [16]. Each participant answers ten Likert items $q_1, \dots, q_{10} \in \{1, \dots, 5\}$. Odd items are positive and even items are negative:

$$\text{SUS} = 2.5 \left[\sum_{i \in \{1,3,5,7,9\}} (q_i - 1) + \sum_{i \in \{2,4,6,8,10\}} (5 - q_i) \right] \quad (6)$$

The result lies in $[0, 100]$; a score above 68 counts as above average.

Task Effectiveness. Effectiveness is the percentage of attempted tasks that users complete successfully:

$$\text{Effectiveness} = \frac{\text{tasks completed}}{\text{tasks attempted}} \times 100\% \quad (7)$$

9.2 Evaluating the Participation Itself

We evaluate PD not only on the product but also on how *democratic* the process was.

Participation Index. If a out of n invited participants actively contributed, the participation index is

$$\text{PI} = \frac{a}{n} \quad (8)$$

A value close to 1 means almost everyone took part.

Average Task Time. The average time that N participants need to finish a task is

$$\bar{t} = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{u=1}^N t_u \quad (9)$$

where t_u is the time participant u needed to finish a task; it should decrease across iterations.

Equality of Voice. Facilitators also check whether participants shared speaking time fairly, so that a few dominant voices did not control the session, and how many user-originated ideas the team actually implemented. Table 5 summarizes the evaluation metrics.

Metric	Measures	Desirable value
SUS	Perceived usability	> 68
Effectiveness	Task success	> 90%
Participation Index	Active involvement	close to 1
Equality of voice	Fair speaking time	balanced

Table 5: Summary of evaluation metrics in Participatory Design

10 Facilitating a Participatory Workshop

Workshops are the heart of PD [17, 18]. A facilitator ensures that every participant, regardless of status or technical skill, can contribute. Algorithm 3 describes the steps of a typical workshop.

Algorithm 3 Running a Participatory Design Workshop

Require: Goal G , participants U , set of available techniques $\mathcal{A}$

- 1: Select techniques $\mathcal{S} \subseteq \mathcal{A}$ suitable for G and participants' skills
 - 2: Prepare materials (cards, sticky notes, paper UI kits, recording)
 - 3: Opening: ice-breaker, ground rules ("no idea is wrong," "users are experts")
 - 4: **for all** activity $a \in \mathcal{S}$ **do**
 - 5: Split U into mixed small groups (users + designers + developers)
 - 6: Run activity a ; use round-robin turns if a few voices dominate
 - 7: Groups present outcomes to the plenary
 - 8: **end for**
 - 9: Collectively prioritize outcomes (dot voting)
 - 10: Document decisions, photos and artifacts; share summary with all participants
 - 11: **return** prioritized ideas and artifacts
-

11 Summary of Techniques

Table 6 maps each technique to the stage in which we use it.

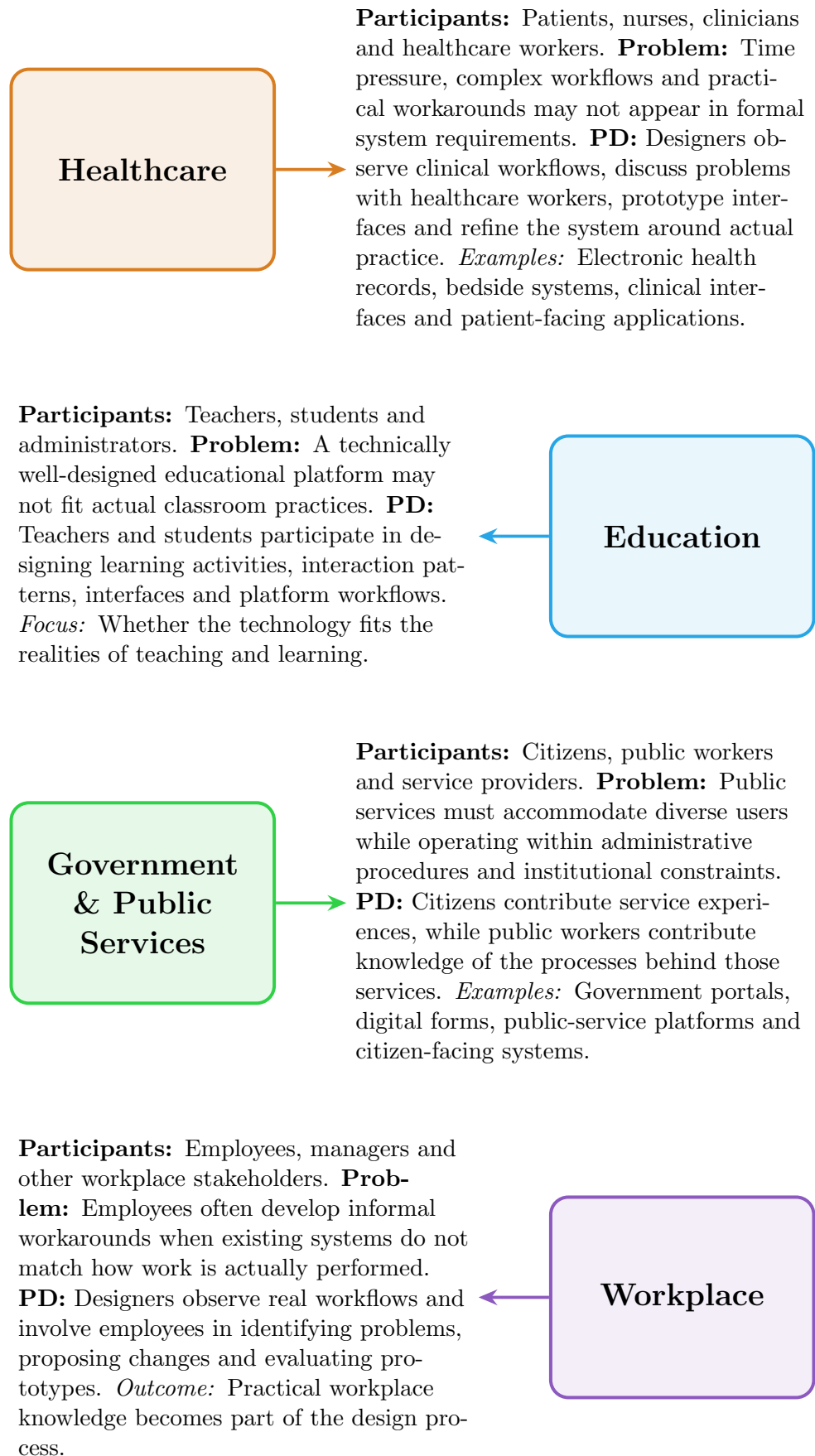
Technique	Stage	Purpose	Output
Contextual Inquiry	Exploration	Understand tacit work practice	Work models
Ethnography	Exploration	Long-term observation of context	Field notes
Future Workshop	Discovery	Move from critique to shared vision	Action plan
Card Sorting	Discovery	Reveal users' mental models	Categories
Affinity Diagram	Discovery	Cluster observations into themes	Theme map
Storytelling	Discovery	Capture real incidents	Scenarios
Design Games	Discovery	Let non-experts express ideas	Concepts
Dot Voting	Discovery	Democratic prioritization	Ranked list
Paper Prototyping	Prototyping	Cheap early testing	Sketches
PICTIVE	Prototyping	Users build interfaces physically	Layouts
Wizard of Oz	Prototyping	Test intelligent features early	Insights
Cooperative Prototyping	Prototyping	Live co-modification of software	Refined UI
SUS / Think-aloud	Evaluation	Measure usability	Scores, issues

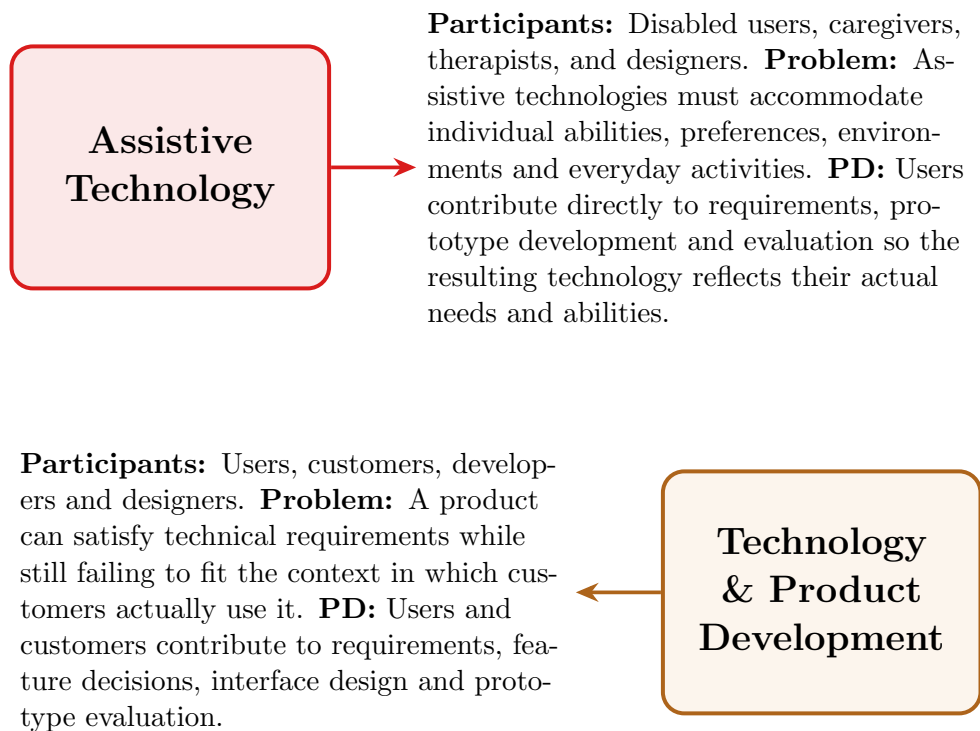
Table 6: Participatory Design techniques mapped to process stages

12 Real-World Applications of Participatory Design

Teams apply Participatory Design in domains where the people affected by a system possess important knowledge about the context in which they will use it. Rather than treating users only as sources of requirements or subjects of evaluation, PD involves them

in shaping the design itself. The following domains illustrate how teams adapt the same principle to different real-world contexts.





Across these domains, the context differs, but the underlying principle is the same: the people who live with a system should have an opportunity to influence its design.

13 Benefits of Participatory Design

We can understand the value of Participatory Design through three connected layers: **people**, **insight** and **outcome**. Participation gives stakeholders a voice, their involvement reveals contextual knowledge, and that knowledge can influence the resulting design.

13.1 Voice and Ownership

Participatory Design gives people affected by a system an opportunity to express their needs and influence design decisions. This can create a stronger sense of ownership because participants can see their contributions reflected in the resulting system.

13.2 Context and Domain Knowledge

Users possess practical knowledge about their everyday work, including workarounds, exceptions, constraints and informal practices. Such knowledge may not appear in formal requirements. Direct participation allows designers to discover this context while the team is still developing the design.

13.3 Improved Usability and Feasibility

Continuous involvement allows users to identify problems in interfaces and workflows before deployment. Participants can also identify whether a proposed solution is realistic within existing practices, resources and organizational constraints.

13.4 Diverse Perspectives and Innovation

Different stakeholders may experience the same system in very different ways. Bringing these perspectives together can reveal problems and possible solutions that would otherwise remain hidden from the design team.

13.5 The Flow of Benefits

These benefits form a flow from people to insight to outcome, which Figure 12 shows. People contribute **voice and ownership**; participation produces **context and knowledge**; and these insights can contribute to **usability, feasibility and innovation**.

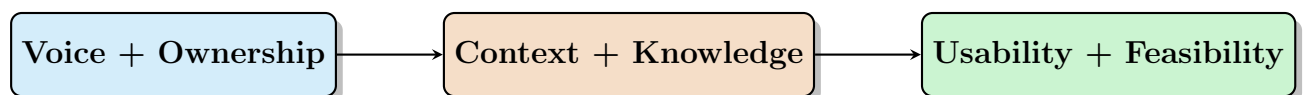


Figure 12: The people–insight–outcome relationship in Participatory Design

14 Challenges of Participatory Design

Participatory Design creates value by involving multiple stakeholders, but participation also introduces practical tensions. Different stakeholders may want different outcomes, participants may have limited time, expectations may become difficult to manage, and some projects involve sensitive information. The challenge is therefore not simply to increase participation, but to structure it effectively.

14.1 Conflicting Needs

Different stakeholders may prioritize different outcomes. For example, in a healthcare system, nurses may prioritize speed, IT staff may prioritize security and compliance, while management may prioritize cost.

Participatory Design does not guarantee agreement. Instead, it provides a setting in which stakeholders can make disagreement visible and discuss trade-offs openly.

Response: Make competing requirements explicit and negotiate trade-offs among stakeholders.

14.2 Time and Logistics

Frontline users are often busy, and bringing people from different roles together can make workshops difficult to organize. Repeated participation may also increase the time required for a project.

Response: Short micro-sessions, targeted participant groups and asynchronous activities can reduce the burden while preserving meaningful participation.

14.3 Trust and Expectations

Participants may question whether designers will actually listen to their contributions. At the same time, participants may expect the team to implement every suggestion, even when technical, financial or organizational constraints make this impossible.

Response: Designers should be transparent about constraints and show participants how their feedback influenced subsequent design decisions.

14.4 Participation and Privacy

Some Participatory Design projects involve sensitive information. Healthcare projects may involve medical records, government projects may involve confidential citizen information, and enterprise projects may contain proprietary information.

Therefore, meaningful participation does not require every participant to have access to every piece of information.

14.4.1 The Need-to-Know Boundary

A useful principle is that participation can be broad in purpose while access remains narrow in scope.

A team can protect sensitive information in four ways, which Table 7 summarizes:

- **Synthetic data** instead of real personal records;
- **Task abstraction** so that participants can discuss workflows without exposing sensitive details;
- **Role-based access** so participants see only information necessary for their contribution;
- **Confidentiality measures** where appropriate.

Protection	Purpose
Synthetic data	Allows participation without exposing real sensitive data
Task abstraction	Separates design discussion from private details
Role-based access	Limits information according to participant needs
Confidentiality	Establishes responsibilities for sensitive information

Table 7: Approaches for balancing participation and privacy

14.5 Managing the Challenges

The four challenges above do not mean that teams should reduce participation. Instead, they show why teams must structure participation deliberately. Table 8 summarizes each challenge and the corresponding response.

Challenge	Problem	Response
Conflict	Stakeholders have different priorities	Open negotiation and explicit trade-offs
Time	Users have limited availability	Short and targeted sessions
Trust	Participants may doubt their influence	Transparency and visible impact
Privacy	Participation may involve sensitive information	Need-to-know access and protected data

Table 8: Major challenges and corresponding responses

15 Conclusion

Participatory Design represents a shift in the way teams conceive and develop systems. Instead of treating users as people for whom designers build a system, PD involves the people affected by the system in shaping it. Figure 13 restates this idea as a flow from people to insight to outcome.



Figure 13: People, insight and outcome in Participatory Design

Its applications demonstrate that this principle is not limited to a single industry. Healthcare, education, government, workplaces, assistive technology and product development all involve situations where users possess important knowledge about the context in which a system operates.

Participation creates value through the connection between people, insight and outcome. Participants contribute their perspectives, which can reveal contextual knowledge, workarounds and diverse needs, ultimately contributing to more usable and feasible designs.

However, participation is not automatically successful. Conflicting needs, limited time, trust and privacy can create significant difficulties. Effective Participatory Design therefore requires carefully structured participation, transparent communication and appropriate boundaries around sensitive information.

15.1 The Central Takeaway

We can summarize the central idea of Participatory Design as a change in design perspective, which Figure 14 shows.

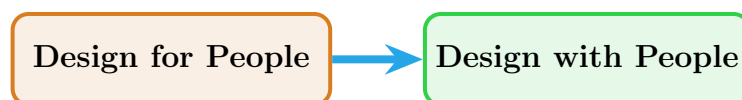


Figure 14: The shift from designing for people to designing with people

Participatory Design therefore matters not simply because designers ask users for their opinions, but because it gives the people affected by a system a meaningful opportunity to help shape it.

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